McManaman. Steve and Zidane, Figo and Guti along with Roberto Carlos were free to get up and support Ronaldo whenever they wanted.

As if any of them needed an invitation. As if Ronaldo needed any help. He scored a fantastic hat-trick in the hour he played. I got the call to go on a couple of minutes after Ronaldo's third goal. I was desperate to be out there. Not to make my point now, just to be involved in an amazing game of soccer: we were 3–2 down on the night, 6–3 down on aggregate, half an hour still to play. The atmosphere when Seba Veron came off and I went on was a bit eerie. He'd played well and deserved the applause. What was weird was that, when I stepped up the slope to the touchline to replace him, it sounded as if the cheer I'd usually get stuck in some people's throats. I could understand the United fans not knowing where they stood with me right at that moment.

'Whose side are you on? Whose side are we on?'

It was uncomfortable. But the uncertainty in the crowd just made me all the more determined to make a mark in the time we had left. A minute or two after I got on, Ronaldo was subbed. He'd had a great game. Everybody inside Old Trafford knew it. The whole crowd got to their feet and gave the bloke the kind of ovation a United player would have got. Never mind we looked like we were being knocked out of the Champions League. The Manchester crowd knows its soccer and they knew they'd been privileged to be there, watching Ronaldo play. I've got my own reasons for having great memories about United's supporters: they always stood by me when I needed them. But I felt really proud of them in a different way that night, watching their reaction as Ronaldo walked off, hands above his head, clapping back.

If I enjoyed Ronaldo's moment, I enjoyed my own even more. We got a free-kick on the edge of the Real penalty area. If I'd been picking and choosing, I might have wanted to be a yard or two further out. The closer you are to goal, the quicker you need to get the ball up and then down again to beat both the wall and the keeper. I'd practiced it tens of thousands of times on my own, on a training field after everyone else had gone home. Teaching my foot, my leg, the rest of my body how it felt when I got it right. And learning how to make it right more and more often. So that now, head swirling, gasping for breath, the future bearing down on me like a dead weight, I could switch distraction off like a light. It's the ball in front of you. The glimpse of white goalpost you can see beyond the wall of defenders. It's the spot on your boot and the angle at which that meets the ball. Step up. Strike. All the practice leaves you knowing, instinctively, when one's on its way, barring a save. I was up in the air before the ball had even settled in the